

Compression

How Does it Sound Different?

- Examples of Compressed and Uncompressed audio



Drum Loop
- 4 measures

Uncompressed/Compressed



Bass Synth
- Phrase

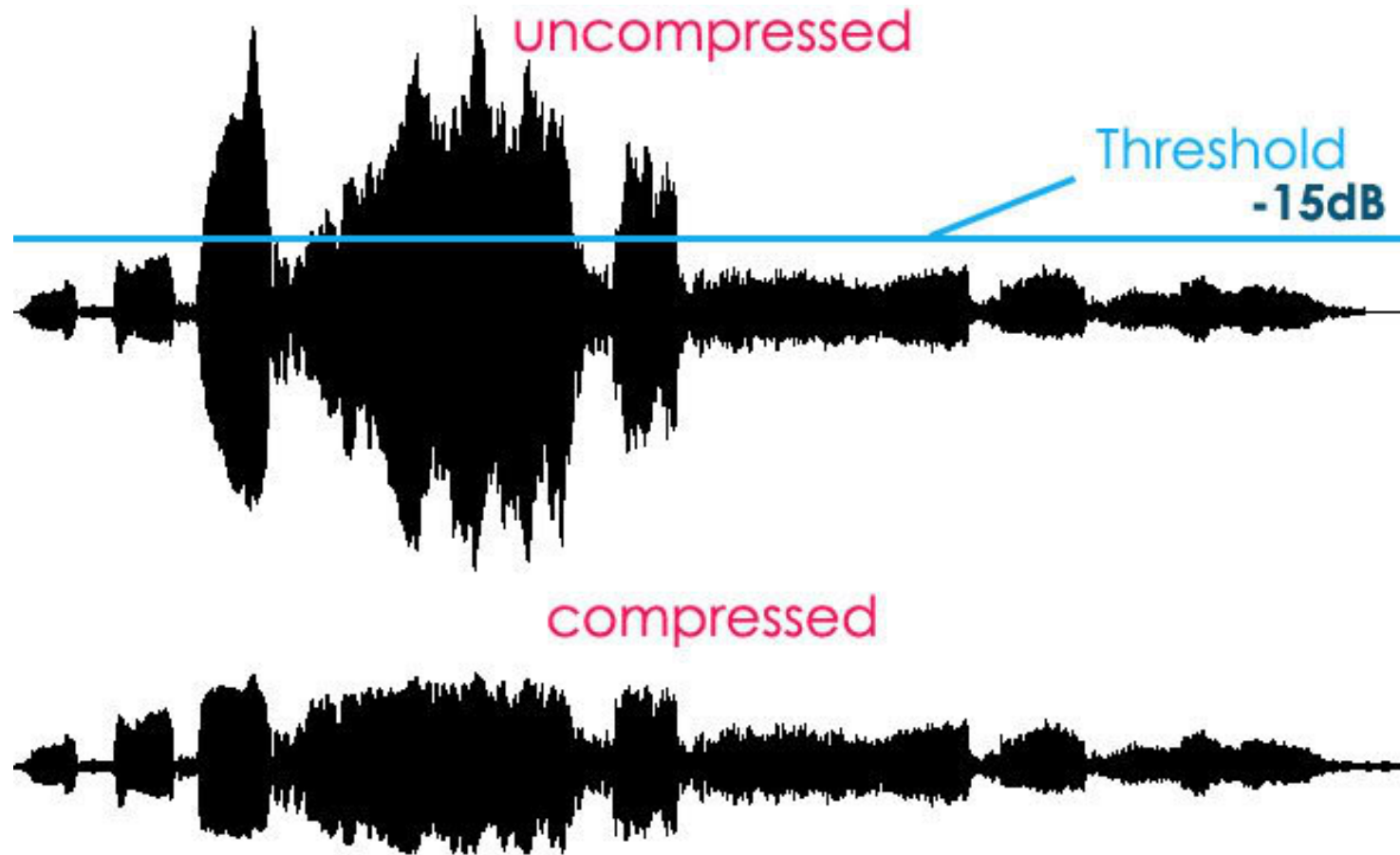
Uncompressed/Compressed



String Section
- Phrase

Uncompressed/Compressed

What's It Actually Doing?



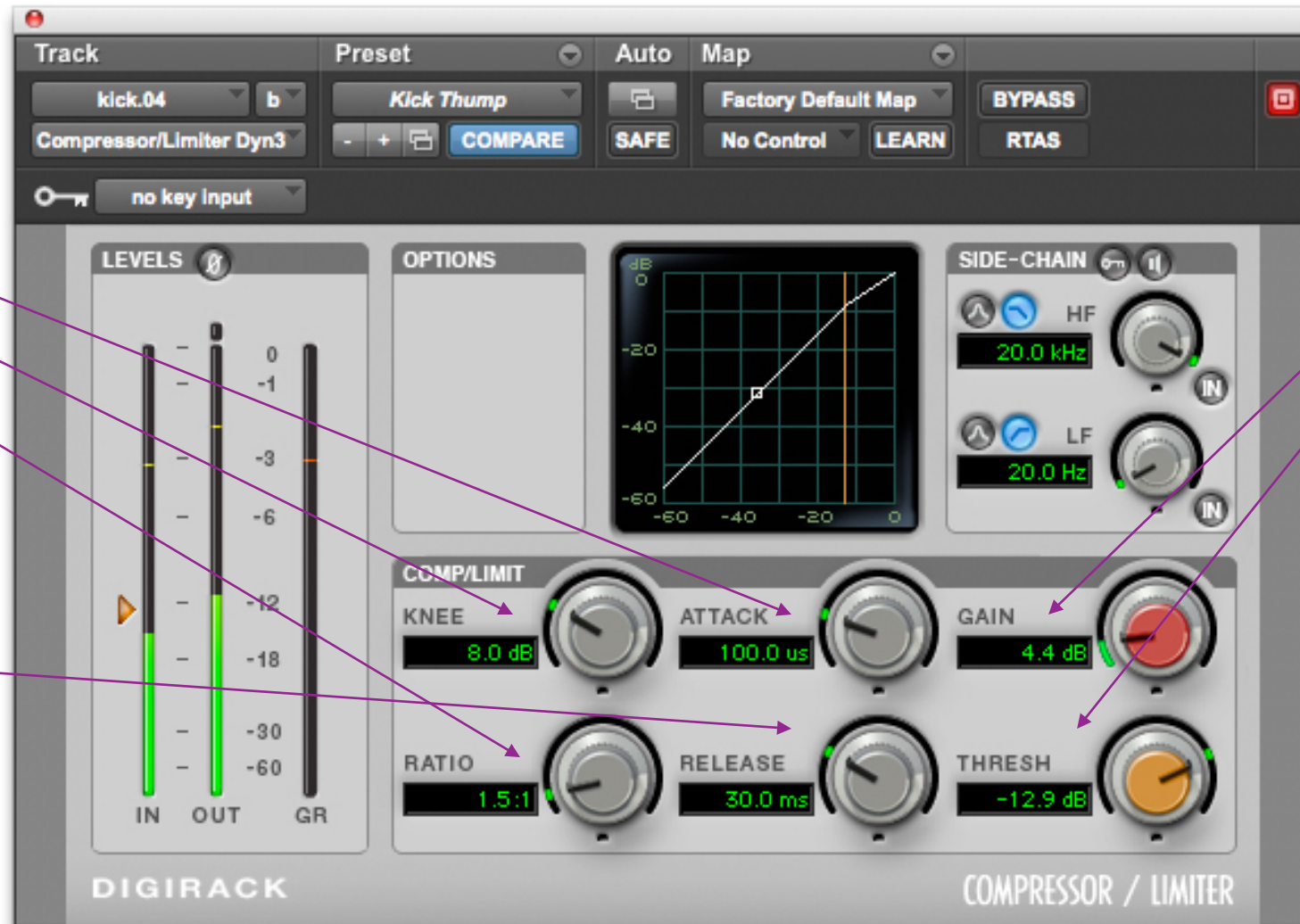
Why Use Compression?

- Loudness Management
 - Lowers transients and decreases range
- Helps Create Hierarchy
 - What elements are compressed
 - Different amounts of compression
 - Forward or backward in Mix
- Changes Timbre
 - Softer qualities of element are louder relative to louder qualities

Compressor Settings

- Attack
- Knee
- Ratio

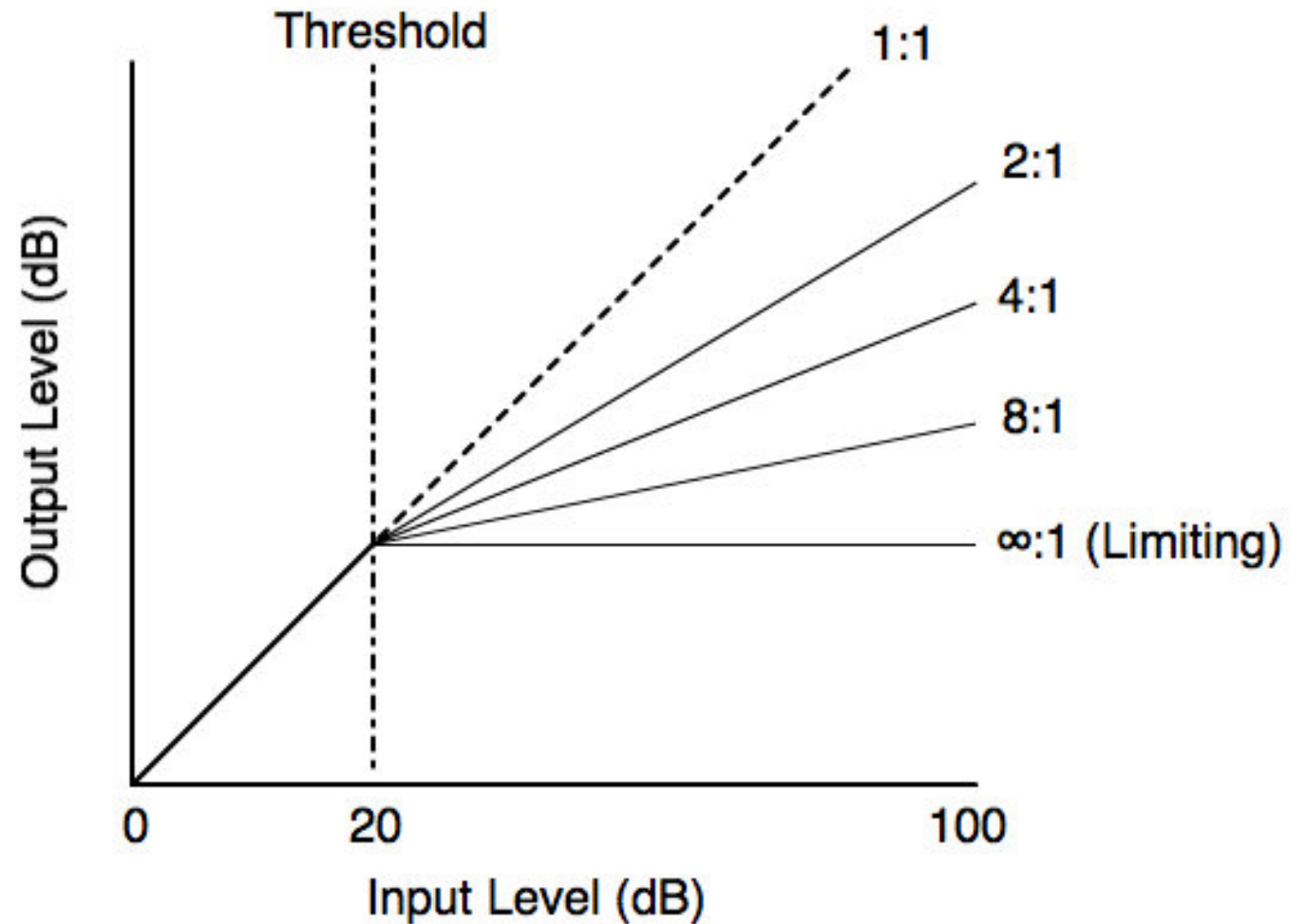
- Release



- (Make-up) Gain
- Threshold

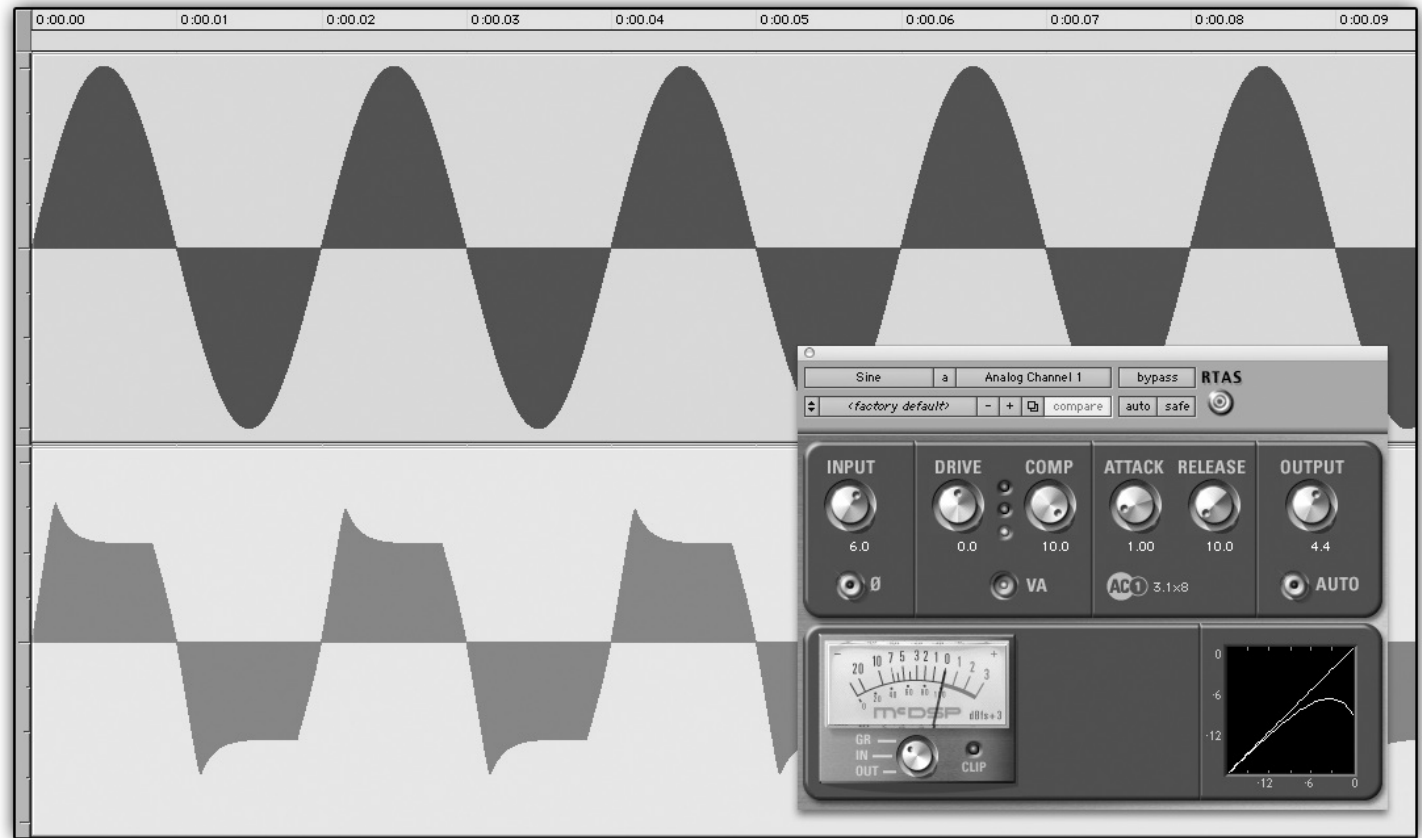
Threshold & Ratio

- Threshold - The level at which the compressor begins to apply compression.
- Ratio – The amount of compression that is applied.



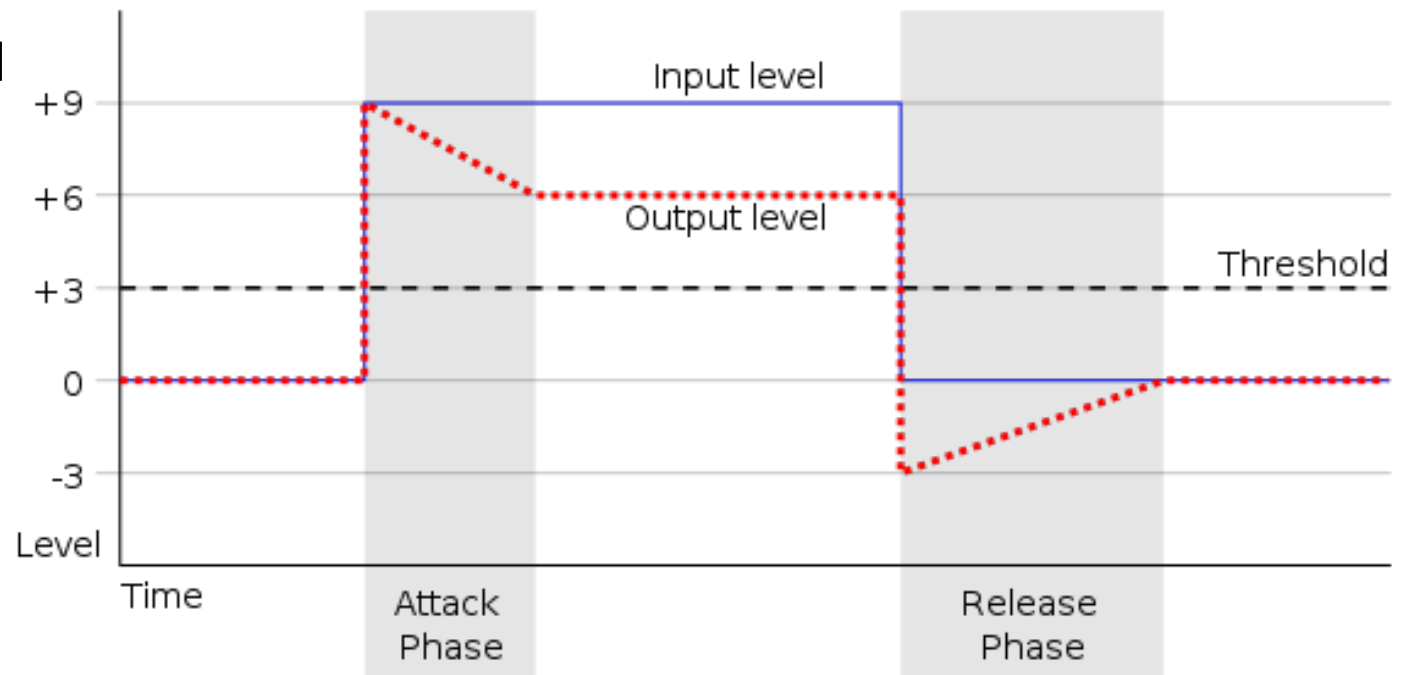
Attack

- Attack – The speed at which compression is applied after the threshold is reached.



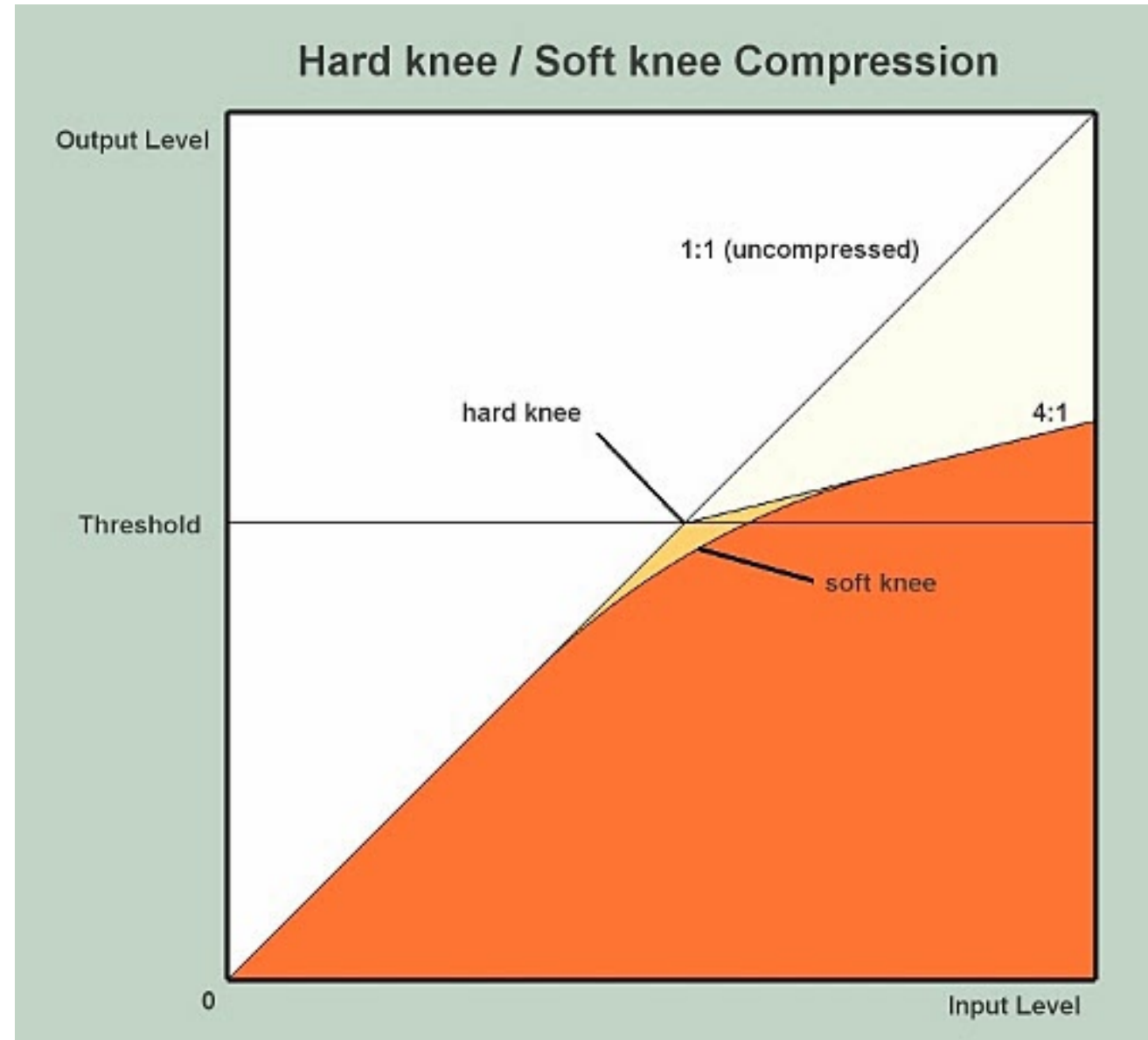
Release

- The speed at which compression is removed when the level falls below the threshold.



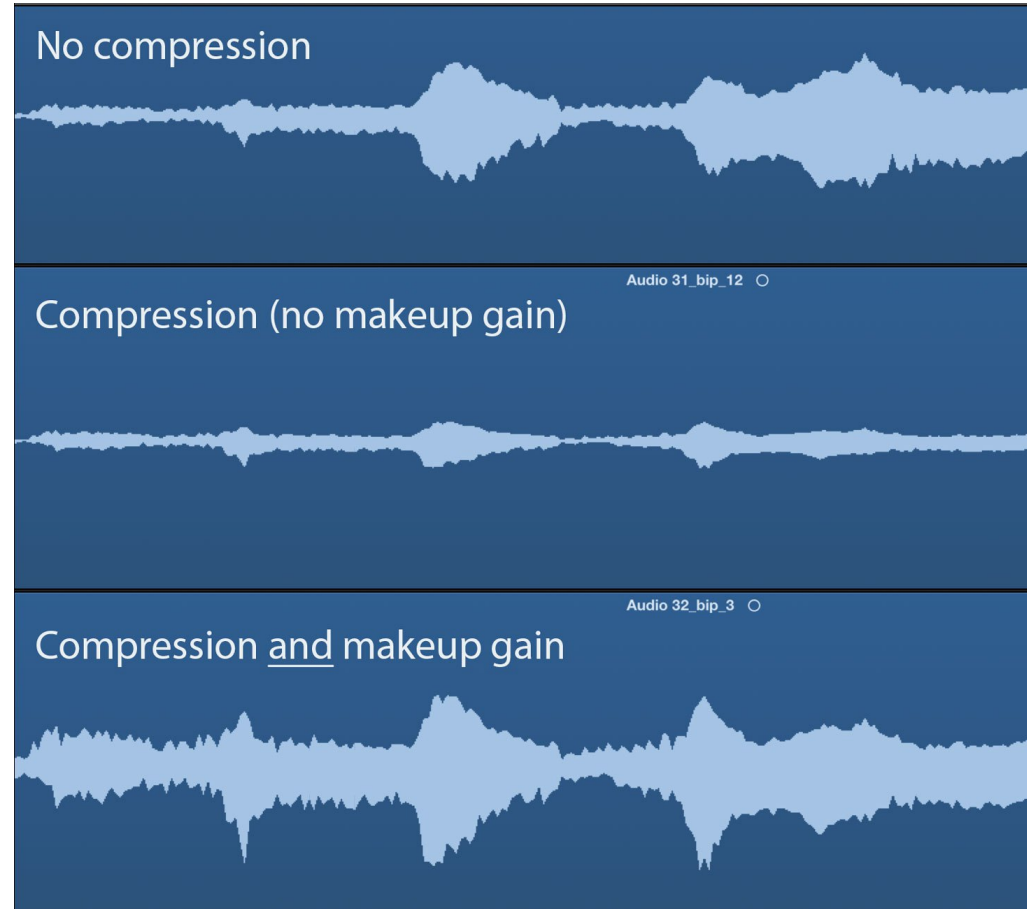
Knee (Q)

- The severity and characteristic of how compression is applied when the level is near the threshold.
- Transparent, “hidden” effect or noticeable?



(Make-up) Gain

- Level of output after compression is applied.
- Make softer qualities louder relative to louder qualities.



Tips and Tricks

- Automate the engagement of compression for different phrases.
- Use different ratio values.
- Apply to “punch through” mix.
- Direct listener's attention.

How to mess it up (don't do these things)

- Apply too much compression
 - Distortion
 - Takes away “natural breathing” quality of sounds
- Neglect to think about how it interacts with other effects - signal flow
 - Compressed reverb? Negating EQ?
- Apply to too many elements in mix
 - If everything is compressed, nothing sounds like it is compressed